



Acts 7:44-50 “Jesus In: The Tabernacle”

Introduction:

- In Acts 6:11-14 Stephen was being falsely accused of blaspheming against Moses, God, the holy place and the law: “for we have heard him say that this Jesus of Nazareth will destroy this place and will change the customs that Moses delivered to us.”
- The religious leaders did not understand the meaning of the promise given to Abraham, the role of God’s servant Moses, the true significance of the Law, or the purpose of the tabernacle and, later, the temple.
- God intended to use these elements as shadows pointing to Jesus Christ, God the Son, who is the only One through whom the relationship between God and men can be restored.

V.44-47. “God dwells among His people”

“Our fathers had the tent of witness in the wilderness, just as he who spoke to Moses directed him to make it, according to the pattern that he had seen. Our fathers in turn brought it in with Joshua when they dispossessed the nations that God drove out before our fathers. So it was until the days of David, who found favor in the sight of God and asked to find a dwelling place for the God of Jacob. But it was Solomon who built a house for him.”

- After freeing the Israelites from Egypt, God instructed them to build a portable tent where He would dwell and where they could gather for worship. “And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst. Exactly as I show you concerning the pattern of the tabernacle, and of all its furniture, so you shall make it.” (Ex.25:8-9).
- The tabernacle was later established inside the promised land (Joshua 18:1) and eventually succeeded by the temple Solomon built, after God told David that his son would build it instead of him (1 Chr. 22:7-10; 1 Kings 6:1).
- God’s glory dwelt in the tabernacle and then the temple until shortly before Jerusalem fell to Babylon (Ezekiel 10:18-19). Despite God’s mercies, His people continuously refused to repent. “The LORD, the God of their fathers, sent persistently to them by his messengers, because he had compassion on his people and on his dwelling place. But they kept mocking the messengers of God, despising his words and scoffing at his prophets, until the wrath of the LORD rose against his people, until there was no remedy.” (2 Chronicles 36:15-16)
- *Stephen’s point was that God’s presence in the tabernacle and the temple did not keep the people from rejecting Him and His prophets. Stephen’s audience was repeating the same pattern by rejecting Jesus.*

V.48-50. “God cannot be confined by people”

“Yet the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands, as the prophet says, ‘Heaven is my throne, and the earth is my footstool. What kind of house will you build for me, says the Lord, or what is the place of my rest? Did not my hand make all these things?’”

- Stephen calls God “Most High” (Greek *hypsistos*, the Old Testament’s *Elyon*, H5945), the only One who transcends His creation. Supporting his claim that God doesn’t dwell in houses made by hands, he quotes Isaiah 66:1-2a.
- From the first chapter in the Bible, God is revealed as the Creator of heavens, earth, and everything in it (Genesis 1; John 1:1-3). He is omnipresent (Psalm 139:7-10; Jeremiah 23:23-24) and can’t be limited to a physical location. Stephen is echoing Solomon’s words at the temple’s dedication: “But will God indeed dwell on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house that I have built!” (1 Kings 8:27).
- *Many religious leaders in Jesus’ day, like their fathers before them, trusted rituals, forms, and external acts (Matthew 23:23-33) as if they secured God’s favor. But God looks to ‘he who is humble and contrite in spirit and trembles at my word’ (Isaiah 66:2b). Jesus said: ‘I tell you, something greater than the temple is here. And if you had known what this means, ‘I desire mercy, and not sacrifice,’ you would not have condemned the guiltless” (Matthew 12:6-7).*

Typology of Jesus in the Tabernacle

The pattern

- In Eden, God walked with Adam and Eve (Genesis 3:8). After sin, they were driven out of the garden because sin separates us from a holy God (Isaiah 59:2; Romans 3:23), and no one can see His face and live (Exodus 33:20).
- Yet God, in His mercy, chose to draw near to His people. His direction to build the tabernacle had at least two key purposes: that He might dwell in their midst (Exodus 25:8) and to give a pattern showing the separation between God and man and the only way to restore our communion. The New Testament calls the pattern “a copy and shadow of the heavenly things” (Hebrews 8:5; Colossians 2:17) pointing ahead to Christ.
- The tabernacle’s pattern (Acts 7:44; Exodus 25:9) began with a courtyard enclosure, a main entrance, a bronze altar for the sacrifices, and a bronze basin for the priests’ washing. The Holy Place held a golden lampstand, the table of the bread of

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Presence, and the golden altar of incense. A veil separated it from the Holy of Holies, which contained the Ark of the Covenant covered with the Mercy Seat (Exodus 25-30). Solomon's temple mostly followed the same pattern (1 Kings 6-8).

- God's presence was manifested as a cloud that would fill up the sanctuary (Exodus 40:34; 1 Kings 8:10), but access was limited. The people could bring sacrifices to the courtyard (Leviticus 1:3-5), but only priests could enter the Holy Place and minister (Numbers 18:1-7). Animal sacrifices were offered daily (Exodus 29:38-42), and only the High Priest could enter the Holy of Holies, once a year, to sprinkle blood on the Mercy Seat (atonement cover) for the sins of the people (Leviticus 16:2, 14-15). Hebrews 9:8 says this showed the way into the holy places was not yet open.

Fulfillment in Christ

- When the fullness of time had come (Galatians 4:4), the glory of God descended in person. John 1:14 says "And the Word became flesh and dwelt [literally tabernacled] among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."
- The Lord Jesus, God the Son (John 1:1; Titus 2:13; Romans 9:5), Immanuel "God with us" (Matthew 1:23), came to dwell with His people, to show us God's face (John 14:9), to restore the broken relationship between God and man. He is the Door (John 10:9), the sacrificial Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world (John 1:29), the One who cleanses us (Titus 3:5), the Light of the world (John 8:12), the Bread of Life (John 6:35), our Intercessor (Romans 8:34), the "new and living way" through the veil (Hebrews 10:20), our Propitiation (Romans 3:25), and our Great High Priest (Hebrews 9:11-15).
- At His death the veil was torn (Matthew 27:51) and He entered once for all into the holy places by means of His own blood (Hebrews 9:12). So now we have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus (Hebrews 10:19).
- As if that were not enough, now God dwells in His people. Jesus promised that He and the Father would come and make their home within those who love Him and keep His word (John 14:23). Christians are the temple of the Holy Spirit collectively (Ephesians 2:21-22) and individually (1 Corinthians 6:19).
- Finally, Jesus is preparing our rooms in His Father's house (John 14:2-3) and God will dwell again with His people (Revelation 21:2-3), and in the New Jerusalem "there will be no temple, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb." (Revelation 21:22).

Conclusion and Main Idea:

Man was created in God's own image (Genesis 1:27) and for His glory (Isaiah 43:7). Sin separates man from his Creator, but Jesus provided a new and living way to restore our relationship with God and to dwell with Him forever. Jesus didn't destroy God's dwelling with man (temple) but rather restored our communion forever.

